Title: Pakistan-Russia Relations: Trends, Opportunities and the Road Ahead

Event Date: October 19, 2026

Venue: CAPES Office

Time: 15:00-16:30

The Consortium for Asia Pacific & Eurasian Studies (CAPES) organized a seminar on "Pakistan-Russia Relations: Trends, Opportunities and the Road Ahead". The seminar featured Pakistan's former Ambassador to Russia and Belarus, Ambassador Zaheer Aslam Janjua, Mr. Artur Makhlaiuk, Research Fellow at the Primakov National Research Institute of World Economy and International Relations of the Russian Academy of Sciences (IMEMO RAS), Moscow, and Dr. Sarwat Rauf, Associate Professor and Head of the Department of International Relations at the National University of Modern Languages (NUML), Islamabad. The event was moderated by Sharjeel Siddiqui, Researcher, CAPES.

Ambassador Janjua began the discussion and said that for decades the Pakistan-Russia relationship was defined by Cold War mistrust and that today's shift is a pragmatic response to a complex security environment. He traced the thaw to the sale of Mi-17 helicopters to Pakistan in 2004 and 2007. This was followed by Russia's lifting of its arms embargo in June 2014, and a defence cooperation agreement signed in Islamabad that November. The agreement led to the first joint exercise, Druzhba, in 2016.

The two countries face extremism, terrorism and separatism, which he noted are the "three evils" named in the SCO charter, along with regional instability and new-generation warfare. He noted that Pakistan has suffered immense human and economic losses, and Russia has faced similar threats in its southern regions and from transnational networks. Both nations share concern about militants exploiting Afghan territory, and about the links between militancy, narcotics, illegal weapons and extremist recruitment. In his words, Afghanistan once divided the two countries and now brings them together.

Ambassador Janjua outlined four pillars of Pakistan-Russia bilateral cooperation. These include Joint Exercises, Institutional Dialogue, Defence Acquisition and Technical Cooperation, as well as Multilateral Coordination. He also outlined some constraints in the relationship, including Russia's deep defence relationship with India and its growing ties with the Taliban government, which complicate coordination. He also pointed out that Western sanctions and the Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA) serve as hindrances in the promotion of bilateral ties.

Ambassador Janjua gave the following recommendations to enhance bilateral ties;

- Deepening counterterrorism and cybersecurity cooperation, including training and intelligence-sharing focused on the Afghan threat and cyber-enabled terrorism.
- Expanding Druzhba and Arabian Monsoon to include more branches and new domains such as electronic warfare and space-based assets.
- Pursuing joint ventures in defence production, maintenance and technology transfer.
- Anchoring security cooperation in trade, energy and connectivity.

He was followed by Mr. Makhlaiuk, who noted that extremist threats now look very different from ten years ago. Radicalization runs through the internet and social media and is increasingly decentralized. Russia and Pakistan face extensive cyber and misinformation campaigns, and both nations can cooperate to combat these threats. Pakistan may want to learn from Russia on counterterrorism and counter-insurgency doctrine, special forces methods, and countering UAVs. Similarly, Russia is interested in Pakistan's operational experience in de-radicalization. Mr. Makhlaiuk further pointed out that the bilateral relationship is under-institutionalized, highlighting that there is no standing joint counterterrorism command or permanent liaison mechanism in either capital. He urged that next steps involve not just governments but those who can implement them in practice.

Dr. Sarwat Rauf stated that cybersecurity and AI are new emerging areas for cooperation. She pointed out that both states are involved in regional connectivity through the Silk Road Economic Belt linking Central and South Asia. However, great power competition, geographical realities and the need for balancing act as constraints to the relationship. She argued that hedging is the best strategy for Pakistan, since it widens policy options without replacing existing relationships. Dr. Rauf further argued that Pakistan and Russia should extend their partnerships through multilateral platforms including the SCO, UN Security Council and BRICS.

Dr. Rauf pointed out that Pakistan-Russia bilateral trade was only at $243 million in 2025, citing payment friction and infrastructure gaps as obstacles. Her recommendations were to choose three to four flagship projects with clear timelines in energy, transit, agriculture or industry. She also advised lowering transaction costs through clear contracts and private-sector facilitation. She also suggested that Pakistan should expand scholarships and people-to-people contact as a way to further bilateral ties.

During the question and answer session, Ambassador Janjua stated that Russia has genuine security concerns because several thousand Russian nationals and Central Asians were recruited by Daesh and can move into Central Asia from Afghanistan. He hoped Russia could encourage Kabul to behave, though he thought this would be difficult. Moreover, Mr. Makhlaiuk explained that Russia sees Afghanistan as part of Central Asia, not South Asia. He postulated that this may explain the impression of limited Russian interest in Pakistan's concerns. Ambassador Janjua

added that while Daesh, rather than TTP, is the bigger threat to Russia, it understands Pakistan's concerns and remains a solid partner.

Ambassador Janjua further proposed a Russia-Pakistan dialogue on countering violent extremism, building on the recent interior ministries' MoU and drawing on NACTA's experience and Pakistan's de-radicalization programmes. He noted that there are no irritants in the bilateral relationship and that any concerns can be addressed through dialogue.

In closing remarks, CAPES' Senior Vice President Dr. Faisal Javaid thanked the speakers and described Afghanistan as the main emerging issue between Pakistan and Russia, given the differing emphasis each places on ISKP and the TTP. He said cooperation on countering violent extremism could serve as an avenue to enhance bilateral ties.

